School Engagement and Purpose in College Students

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Abstract

Past studies have examined the role of having a sense of purpose in the success of college students, but few have determined a direct relationship between college students' school engagement and sense of purpose. Attempting to investigate the connection further, this study employed correlational analyses with data from 2,074 community students nationwide to examine the relationship between school engagement and purpose. Consistent with the hypothesis, correlational analyses demonstrated a moderate positive correlation between school engagement and a sense of purpose and meaning in life. Additionally, honor society membership status, whether one had a mentor, college size, and college credits earned, were each linked to school engagement and purpose. Purpose was also positively correlated with age, and significant results were found for purpose in employment hours per week, gender identity, and the number of college credits earned. Future examination of factors in the connection between purpose and school engagement may lead to the development of methods to increase school engagement and a sense of purpose in college students.

Keywords: school engagement, purpose, college students, honor societies

As rates of mental health conditions such as anxiety, depression, and suicidal ideation climb among adolescents, finding factors that increase well-being is critical to learning how to protect college students' mental health (Wang et al., 2022). Two factors that may protect mental health are purpose and school engagement. This study aimed to analyze the relationship between these factors. Purpose pertains to setting and intentionally working toward goals and feeling as if one's life and actions are meaningful (Hudig et al., 2021). Having a sense of purpose greatly benefits the mental health and wellbeing of college students. Purpose motivates them to overcome obstacles by fostering the belief that one's life and actions are important (Hudig et al., 2021; Wang et al., 2022). Hill et al. (2022) found purpose to be a predictor of daily positive affect as well as experiencing more daily positive events. Purpose is especially important for adolescents with marginalized identities, as it is a significant factor in resilience, community connection, and the desire to challenge systemic oppression (Sepulveda et al., 2021). School engagement is the level a student feels involved in, respected, and unconditionally accepted at their academic institution (Hagborg, 1998). Little information is known about the effects of school engagement on the well-being of college students; however, higher school engagement relates to higher educational aspirations and a greater sense of control over academic outcomes in middle school students (Hagborg, 1998).

Previous research has found connections between purpose and study or academic engagement. However, the connection between school engagement and purpose has yet to be examined. Envisioning a meaningful future, a core

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element of purpose, mediated the link between parental and school relationships and academic engagement in high school students (Hill et al., 2018). Similarly, high schoolers who engaged in a program designed to increase the beyond-the-self aspect of purpose had higher grade point averages, which could indicate increased school engagement (Sepulveda et al., 2021). Studies investigating purpose and school engagement in university students found that purpose was significantly related to study engagement; this differs from school engagement because study engagement pertains specifically to a student's absorption in and commitment to studying, as well as their perception of studying as meaningful (Hudig et al., 2021). Life satisfaction, also an element of purpose, and study engagement were both predicted by self-congruence, an aspect of personal autonomy (Bandzevičienė & Paradnikė, 2015).

Although the relationship between purpose and study engagement or academic success has been investigated, little is known about how purpose and school engagement are related. Examining the relationship between school engagement and purpose may reveal insight into how the link between a student's sense of purpose and involvement in their academic institution differs from the relationship between a student's sense of purpose and their academic standing or interest in studying.

Methods

Participants

This project surveyed students from 89 community colleges nationwide. This study had 2,074 participants after cleaning the data; however, the total number of participants in each analysis varies because of missing data. A total of 11% of participants were members of an honor society such as Alpha Gamma Sigma, Psi Beta, and Phi Theta Kappa. Most participants identified their gender as female (67%), followed by male (26%), and 4% declined to answer or indicated another identity. A total of 41% of participants identified as being part of a minority racial group, 46% did not, and 13% declined to answer. Participants ranged from 18 to 82 years old with a mean age of 24 years.

Measures

The Psychological Sense of School Membership was used to measure school engagement. The Psychological Sense of School Membership scale is an 18-item scale that measures a student's sense of belonging and connection to their academic institution (Goodenow, 1993). Some items on the scale include: "I am included in lots of activities at my current college" and "I am treated with as much respect as other students." Participants were asked to rate these on a scale from 1 (*not true*) to 5 (*completely true*). This scale has previously found school engagement to increase academic motivation and to be related to academic outcomes (Goodenow, 1993). To measure purpose, The Claremont Purpose Scale (CPS) was used. The CPS is a 12-item scale used to evaluate a student's sense of direction in life and their sense of life meaning and purpose (Bronk et al., 2018). Some questions on this scale include: "How clearly do you understand what it is that makes your life feel worthwhile?" and "How important is it to you to make the world a better place in some way?" Participants were asked to answer these on a 1 (*not*) to 5 (*extremely*) scale. This measure focused on three domains of purpose: goal-orientedness, personal meaning, and beyond-the-self orientation (Bronk et al., 2018).

Procedure

Data collection for this study began after approval from the Institutional Review Board at Wenatchee Valley College. All participants were emailed a link to an online survey on Google Forms by fellow students or professors. Professors had the option to grant a small amount of extra credit for participation. Participants were asked to certify that they were at least 18 years of age and to provide informed consent to participation. The survey included questions about sociodemographic factors, including honor society membership

Table 1

Means, Standard Deviations, and ANOVA Statistics for School Engagement

Measure	School engagement		ANOVA		
	M	*SD*	*F*	*df*	ηp²
Mentor			86.14***	2, 2984	.08
Yes	3.9	0.6			
Unsure	3.7	0.6			
No	3.5	0.7			
College size			3.83*	3, 1964	.01
Less than 5,000	3.7	0.7			
5,000-9,999	3.6	0.7			
10,000-19,999	3.7	0.7			
20,000 or more	3.7	0.7			
Earned college credit			2.57*	4, 1954	.01
0	3.7	0.6			
1-29	3.7	0.7			
30-59	3.6	0.7			
60-89	3.8	0.6			
90+	3.7	0.7			

*$p < .05$, ***$p < .001$

status, age, and gender identity. At the end of the questionnaire, a debriefing page explained the purpose of the study and provided mental health crisis resources.

Results

Correlational analysis was used to determine the relationship between mean school engagement scores and mean purpose scores. These variables were moderately positively correlated, $r(1961) = .43$, $p < .001$, 95% CI [.39, .46]. A weak positive correlation was also found between the mean purpose score and age, $r(2034) = .24$, $p < .001$, 95% CI [.20, .28]. The correlation between school engagement score and age was weak, $r(1993) = .12$, $p < .001$, 95% CI [.08, .17].

An independent *t*-test identified a significant difference in mean school engagement scores between participants who were members of an honor society ($M = 3.9$, $SD = 0.7$) and those who were not ($M = 3.7$, $SD = 0.7$), $t(1991) = 4.98$, $p < .001$, $d = 0.35$, 95% CI [0.14, 0.33]. A significant difference was also found in mean purpose scores between participants who were members of an honor society ($M = 4.1$, $SD = 0.7$) and those who were not ($M = 3.8$, $SD = 0.7$), $t(2032) = 4.75$, $p < .001$, $d = 0.34$, 95% CI [0.15, 0.35].

Analysis of variance (ANOVA) assessed the differences between sociodemographic factors related to school engagement scores. Participants' average school engagement score was 3.7 ($SD = 0.7$) on a scale from 1 to 5. There was a significant result for school engagement scores between participants who self-identified as having a mentor, those who were unsure whether they had a mentor, and those who self-identified as not having a mentor (see Table 1). A Tukey's HSD test revealed

Table 2

Means, Standard Deviations, and ANOVA Statistics for Purpose

Measure	Purpose		ANOVA		
	M	*SD*	*F*	*df*	ηp²
Mentor			40.46***	2, 2026	.04
Yes	4.0	0.7			
Unsure	3.8	0.7			
No	3.7	0.8			
College size			3.83***	3, 1964	.01
Less than 5,000	3.9	0.7			
5,000-9,999	3.8	0.8			
10,000-19,999	3.9	0.7			
20,000 or more	3.9	0.7			
Weekly work hours			7.81***	2, 2021	.01
Not employed	3.8	0.7			
Less than 20	3.8	0.7			
More than 20	3.9	0.7			
Gender			10.13***	2, 2009	.01
Female	3.9	0.7			
Male	3.8	0.7			
Other	3.6	0.7			
Earned college credit			5.89***	4, 1973	.01
0	3.8	0.7			
1-29	3.8	0.7			
30-59	3.8	0.7			
60-89	4.0	0.7			
90+	4.1	0.7			

***$p < .001$.

a significantly higher mean purpose score in those who self-identified as having a mentor compared with those who either were unsure or those who self-identified as not having a mentor ($p < .001$). There was also a significant difference between college size (see Table 1). A Tukey's HSD test revealed a significant difference between college sizes. Colleges with over 20,000 students had the highest mean school engagement scores and colleges with between 5,000 and 9,999 had the lowest. Additionally, number of college credits earned predicted school engagement. Post hoc analysis using Tukey's HSD test ($p < .05$) revealed significant differences between those with 30-59 credits and 60-89 credits. Employment hours per week, $F(2, 1980) = 0.63$, $p = .532$, $\eta p^2 = .01$ and gender identities, $F(2, 1986) = 2.04$, $p = .106$, $\eta p^2 < .01$ did not predict school engagement. ANOVA was used to assess the differences between sociodemographic factors related to purpose

scores. Participants' average purpose score was 3.8 (SD = 0.7) on a scale from 1 to 5. Mentorship predicted purpose scores (see Table 2). Post hoc analysis using Tukey's HSD test ($p < .001$) revealed significant differences between those who self-identified as having a mentor and those who were unsure, those who self-identified as not having a mentor and those who were unsure, and those who self-identified as having a mentor and those who self-identified as not having a mentor. There was also a significant difference between college size (see Table 2). Post hoc analysis using Tukey's HSD test ($p < .001$) revealed significant differences between colleges with over 20,000 students and colleges with between 5,000 and 9,999. There were also significant differences in mean purpose score among employment hours per week (see Table 2). Post hoc analysis using Tukey's HSD test ($p < .001$) revealed significant differences between those who were employed more than 20 hours per week and those who were employed less than 20 hours per week, as well as between those who were employed more than 20 hours per week and those who were not employed. Mean purpose scores were also significantly different among gender identity (see Table 2). Tukey's HSD test ($p < .01$) indicated significant differences existed between female and other, as well as between female and male, with the female group having the highest mean purpose score. Additionally, mean purpose score differences were significant between the number of college credits earned (see Table 2). Post hoc analysis using Tukey's HSD test ($p < .01$) revealed significant differences between those with 1-29 credits and 60-89 credits, as well as between those with 1-29 credits and more than 90 credits.

Discussion

This study measured the correlation between school engagement and purpose in college students, as well as to investigate if there were differences in either school engagement scores or purpose scores between sociodemographic factors. A moderate correlation was found between school engagement scores and purpose scores. This finding suggested a link between feeling respected and accepted in one's school environment and a sense of purpose and personal meaning. Similarly, this finding suggested a connection between feeling driven to accomplish one's goals and meaningfully engaging in one's school environment. The results are nearly identical to the results of similar studies conducted in the past, specifically one that found a moderate correlation ($r = .47$) between study engagement and purpose (Hudig et al., 2021). Hudig et al. (2021) suggested that this finding indicated that having a sense of purpose in life drives students' motivation to engage in schoolwork. Additionally, Hudig et al. (2021) proposed that students understanding the value of their schoolwork in helping them accomplish their future goals may lead them to invest more time and energy into completing it. Another study by Hill et al. (2018) found that when students' sense of purpose was fostered by supportive parents, those students had higher academic achievement. Hill et al. (2018) suggested this finding implies that students with these supportive relationships were more likely to view academic engagement as an important step to reaching their goals.

Analysis of mean school engagement scores between sociodemographic factors revealed several significant findings. These include differences in school engagement between honor society membership status, mentor status, college size, and college credit. Participants who were members of an honor society and those who self-identified as having a mentor had both the highest mean school engagement scores and the highest mean purpose scores. Membership in an honor society could foster a sense of purpose in college students, or having a higher sense of direction and motivation to achieve life goals could encourage college students to join an honor society. This relationship may be bidirectional. Similarly, students with a mentor may receive more guidance, encouraging them to set goals and motivating them

to achieve them. Alternatively, students who have a higher drive to achieve life goals may be more inclined to seek a mentor. Participants who were members of an honor society likely overlapped with participants who self-identified as having a mentor. The highest mean school engagement and purpose scores between college sizes were in colleges with more than 20,000 students, while the lowest mean school engagement and purpose scores were found in colleges with between 5,000 and 9,999 students. This may be because of larger colleges having more opportunities for engagement, such as sports teams and clubs. No previous studies have examined differences in school engagement between honor society membership status, mentorship status, or campus size.

Significant findings between employment hours per week, gender identity, and number of college credits earned were also found with purpose scores. Participants who were employed more than 20 hours per week had the highest mean purpose score, followed by those who were employed less than 20 hours a week, and finally, those who were not employed. This finding may suggest that those who are employed more than 20 hours per week feel as if their life is meaningful and they are working to meet their goals more than those who are employed less than 20 hours a week or those who are not employed. This finding may also suggest that those with a higher sense of purpose and drive to meet their goals are more motivated to work more than 20 hours per week. Between gender identities, participants who identified as female had the highest mean purpose scores, followed by participants who identified as male, and finally, participants who had a gender identity that was not male or female. However, school engagement scores were not significantly different between gender identities. This finding could indicate that another factor caused higher purpose scores in female participants than male participants and other gender participants.

A significant correlation was also found between age and purpose scores, suggesting that an individual's sense of purpose increases with age. Few studies have previously investigated the correlation between age and sense of purpose, and none have addressed this correlation among college students. This study addressed school engagement, rather than study engagement or academic success, which are the factors that have been investigated by similar previous studies. This study, therefore, examined a previously unexplored aspect of the interaction between purpose and students' interactions with their school environments. This study also observed differences in school engagement and purpose within groups between mentorship status, honor society status, gender identity, employment hours per week, number of college credits earned, and campus size. Few of these sociodemographic factors have been examined in school engagement or purpose in previous studies.

A broad limitation of this study is that causation cannot be determined due to the nature of correlational analyses. A larger number of participants would more accurately represent the relationships between the measures and demographic factors. Additionally, both school engagement and purpose scores demonstrate a ceiling effect, potentially skewing the data and challenging the validity of the results. The data set was also overwhelmingly composed of students who were not members of an honor society. Grade point average (GPA) could not be accurately compared to school engagement or purpose because of the survey not collecting information on what scale participants' GPA was relative to, meaning some participants entered their GPA relative to a 4.0 grading scale, and some entered their GPA relative to a 5.0 or another grading scale. Future research could more accurately investigate the relationship between school engagement and GPA in college students, as this relationship has not been investigated in college students before. Additionally, this study did not collect information

on participants' racial and ethnic identities, only whether they identified as members of a minority racial group. What racial identities fall under the category of a racial minority group was not defined in the survey that participants filled out. Because of this, as well as having a high percentage of participants decline to answer (13%), the investigated measures could not be adequately examined between ethnic and racial groups. Future research could also identify possible reasons those in an honor society and those who self-identify as having a mentor have higher purpose and school engagement, as well as what factors may cause the difference between mean school engagement score and mean purpose score for colleges of different sizes. The correlation between age and mean purpose score could also be investigated further, as well as examining other factors that may contribute to this relationship.

This study aimed to investigate the relationship between school engagement and purpose and found that a moderate positive correlation exists between the two, as well as differences among several sociodemographic factors. Especially significant findings include differences in both school engagement and purpose between groups regarding honor society membership, mentorship status, and college campus size. As participation and engagement increase, we also see an increase in sense of belonging and purpose. These findings may hold important implications for those seeking to increase school engagement or purpose in community college students. As mental health declines in college students, we see that supporting goal setting, fostering motivation to take the necessary steps to achieve goals, and encouraging the development of a sense of personal meaning are critical to the well-being of students.

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